EXHIBITION ▼

LIVING HISTORIES

A DEDICATED CONTEMPORARY INDIAN ART EXHIBITION IS OPENING AT ST. PETERSBURG'S STORIED HERMITAGE MUSEUM

For the first time in its 260-year history, the State Hermitage Museum in St. Petersburg is presenting a focused view of India's contemporary art. *Sediments of Becoming: Fossilised Present, Summoned Pasts* showcases works of 11 Indian artists along with historical objects like icons, frescoes and decorative art from the Hermitage's collection. "The overarching concern was about narrative authority—about art that is considered complex enough, rigorous enough and urgent enough to stand alongside the masters in an institution of world standing," says Tunty Chauhan, director of Delhi's Gallery Threshold and co-curator of the exhibition with Marina Schulz, head of the Hermitage's contemporary art department.



FOREVER GOLDEN Lakshmi Madhavan's *Kasavu*

Sediments of Becoming **showcases the works of 11 Indian artists, many of whom have produced new works for the exhibition**

Works include a multimedia installation by Afrah Shafiq that builds an archive of Soviet-era fairy tales in the form of a video game; Debasish Mukherjee's mixed media on linen that maps how rapid urbanisation is transforming India's heritage cities; conceptual artist Lakshmi Madhavan's *Kasavu* (traditional gold/ silver borders that are a symbol of Kerala's textiles) that highlights the cultural memory of the weaver and V. Ramesh's triptych celebrating the life of Nandanar, a 7th-century Dalit saint who overcame social barriers through intense devotion. "The artists were selected across genres to show the conceptual rigour of their practice," says Chauhan. "It was a conscious effort to choose mid-career artists with a distinct vocabulary."

Contemporary Indian art has not been shown in Russia in recent years. "The exhibition emerged not from official visits or institutional exchanges but from friendships, horizontal connections and a desire to understand the other," says Schulz. ■

—Prachi Joshi

The exhibition will be on display from Jun. 4 to Oct. 4



SHAH OF SHAHS Abu'l Fazl giving the *Akbarnama* to emperor Akbar, c.1603-1605

ART ▼

CROSS CURRENTS

An exhibition focuses on the shared civilisational memory of Iran and India

At Sunder Nursery in Delhi, the exhibition *Shared Epic Worlds: The Shahnameh, the Mahabharata, and the Indo-Persian Imagination* explores the deep literary and cultural connections between Iran and India through epic manuscripts, translation traditions, painting and shared memory. Presented by the Aga Khan Trust for Culture in collaboration with the Noor International Microfilm Centre (NIMC) in Iran, at the heart of the exhibition is the relationship between the Shahnameh and the Mahabharata, two monumental works that still shape the cultural imagination of their respective civilisations. "The deepest resonances between the Shahnameh and the Mahabharata are not to be found in superficial similarities, but in their shared grammar of epic narration and in their common ethical and philosophical core," says Shahab Khajeh Piri, deputy director, NIMC.

THE SHAHNAMEH **AND THE MAHABHARATA** HAVE A COMMON ETHICAL AND PHILOSOPHICAL CORE

The exhibition revisits the Mughal translation movement initiated under Akbar through the Maktab Khana, or House of Translation, where Hindu and Muslim scholars collaborated to translate Sanskrit texts into Persian. ■

—Nikhil Sardana

The exhibition will run till Jun. 4